

2. Social-Emotional Development

Objective language for documenting emotional responses, self-regulation, and relationships.

Describe what the child does during emotional moments — not what you think the child feels or intends. Note duration, triggers, and what helped.

Emotion Expression — Observable Signs		
tears ran down face	cried audibly for ____ minutes	smiled broadly
laughed aloud	giggled	frowned
furrowed brow	tightened jaw	clenched fists
crossed arms	turned body away	covered face with hands
hid under furniture	jumped with excitement	clapped hands
stomped feet	screamed	whimpered
held breath briefly	took a slow breath	

Self-Regulation Behaviors		
took three deep breaths	walked to the calm-down corner	requested a break
used a fidget tool	sat quietly for ____ seconds before responding	used words to express frustration
identified the feeling by name	used a visual support to calm	returned to activity within ____ minutes
needed adult co-regulation for ____ minutes	calmed with verbal support	calmed with physical proximity of an adult
calmed with preferred object	calmed after movement break	calmed independently

Transition Between Emotional States		
moved from distress to calm within ____ minutes	recovered after adult acknowledged the feeling	re-engaged with activity after ____
needed ____ minutes before rejoining the group	accepted comfort from the adult	pushed comfort away initially, then accepted
self-initiated return to activity	required redirection ____ times before re-engaging	

Relationships & Attachment Behaviors		
sought adult proximity during ____	checked in visually with the adult every ____	greeted the adult by name
waved goodbye at departure	expressed reluctance to separate at drop-off	separated from caregiver within ____ minutes

initiated physical affection with the adult	responded warmly to adult greetings	showed preference for a specific adult
sought adult help when frustrated		

3. Communication & Language

Objective terms for documenting how a child communicates — expressively and receptively.

Note the child's primary communication mode, specific examples, and the context. Document the child's approximate vocabulary, use of sentences, and how others respond.

Expressive Language — What the Child Produces		
used single words	used two-word combinations	used short sentences (3–4 words)
used complete sentences	used gestures only	used pointing to indicate needs
used vocalizations without words	approximated words (e.g., said '___' for '___')	echoed adult speech (immediate echolalia)
repeated phrases from books or videos	asked questions using 'what' 'where' 'why'	named objects
described actions	shared experiences verbally	communicated using a device or picture symbols
used sign language	combined words and gestures	initiated conversation
responded to conversational partner		

Receptive Language — How the Child Understands		
followed a one-step direction	followed a two-step direction	followed a three-step direction with visual support
responded to their name	responded to name after ___ attempts	identified objects when named
pointed to pictures when named	understood positional concepts (on, under, beside)	followed classroom routines without verbal prompting
required visual or gestural cue to follow direction	did not respond to verbal direction alone	looked toward sound or voice
understood simple questions		

Fluency & Articulation (Describe, Do Not Diagnose)		
speech was understood by familiar adults	speech was understood by unfamiliar adults	speech required clarification ___ times during observation
repeated initial sounds or syllables	paused frequently before responding	spoke in a soft voice
spoke very loudly in all settings	varied volume and tone	spoke at a very fast rate